

Reefer Madness: Harry J Anslinger

Sam Ritter
POLSB372

Background

- Harry J Anslinger was the head of the Federal Bureau of Narcotics (FBN) from 1930-1962
- Shortly into that tenure (~1934) he began his campaign against marijuana, what he called the “killer weed.”
 - Set the foundation for nearly all of the judicial marijuana infrastructure we have today
- His extended work set precedent for minimum sentencing and criminalization of other drugs
- Explicitly racist motives
- Has more or less flown under the radar due to the stardom of his well-known rival, J Edgar Hoover

Overview

- Anslinger used explicitly racist rhetoric to argue for drug criminalization. I intend to draw direct links from his rhetoric and strategies to federal laws still in existence today.
- I intend to show these laws/policies
 - cause disproportionate harm to communities of color
 - prolong and worsen addiction - they are in the best interest of the state, not the people
 - have explicitly racist roots
- I will focus primarily on marijuana legislation and its consequences then and in the modern era

Process and Approach

- There are two main books on Anslinger and his policies: McWilliams' *The Protectors* and Sloman's *Reefer Madness*
 - McWilliams portrays Anslinger as a well-intentioned bureaucrat led astray by his own sensationalizing
 - Sloman portrays Anslinger as a contributor to a racist system and racist himself, though he does do his own fair share of sensationalizing
- I also have several books/articles by Anslinger himself
 - I intend to find evidence of his thought processes connected to tangible elements of later laws and policies
- I intend to use Anslinger's introspection and biographies of him to demonstrate his intent behind criminalization
 - I will then draw parallels between his work in criminalization and the harm it causes today

Next Steps

- Find a proper breadth of sources on drug legislation, in particular that of the War on Drugs era and post-PATRIOT act/transition to War on Terror
 - legislative tactics did not change, but rhetoric did
 - I'd also like to find stats from COVID, where the prison system released a number of individuals with drug-related crimes who did not become the raging monsters Anslinger predicted (who would've guessed)
- continue to limit my scope
 - look this guy was involved in everything from Hollywood acting to MK-Ultra I have to draw the line somewhere
- continue reading through the 4 books I'm using for this project
- Write The Paper.